

Florence at Walking Pace

Ponte Vecchio, a closed hat shop, a great brunch, and dinner by Palazzo Vecchio

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The first full morning in Florence began properly: out from the Airbnb and across the **Ponte Vecchio**, letting the city reveal itself at walking pace rather than schedule pace. The morning target was **Cappelli Antonio Gatto**, the hatmaker, though the shop was not open on this stroll — a small frustration, but hardly a defeat.

Coffee and pastry came at **Caffè Bellini**, across the street from the **Giardino di Boboli**. A good Florentine morning needs very little ceremony: a bridge, a café, something sweet, and enough time not to hurry.

Brunch was at **Osteria Belguardo**, with fried sage, calamari, spinach salad, and peas with prosciutto. That made the morning feel less like sightseeing and more like settling into the rhythm of the place: walk, look, eat well, keep a few possibilities open.

Later, the walk carried through the courtyard of the **Uffizi Gallery**, past the tower, and into the civic heart of Florence at **Palazzo Vecchio**. Outside, in **Piazza della Signoria**, stood the outdoor copy of Michelangelo's *David* — the sort of public art that makes a city feel less like a museum and more like a civilization that left its doors open.

That statue also became a family thread: the text exchange with the grandson about *David*, along with the photos, belongs in the final record of this trip — not lost in the heathen swamp of message history.

Dinner was outdoors by **Palazzo Vecchio**: pizza, burrata, salad, and rosé. The evening finished in the proper Italian manner, with gelato on the walk back to the Airbnb.